Does AI Reduce Human Autonomy in Decision Making?

CSET 485: AI and Society | Self-Learning Assignment

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1. Introduction

AI is past the point of confinement to research facilities and niche industries, however-fundamental choices encroached: what news or film to devour; which course should one take; which of the various items you should buy and when how data will be introduced. AI is used in organisations to make decisions about healthcare, employment, finance, education and public administration and security. This raises an important ethical question: if people depend upon systems to predict rank recommend or decide for them, are they truly in control? In fact human autonomy is the ability with which we can say a human has control of his or her actions, decisions. However, when it comes to ethics of AI, autonomy is far less black and white in meaning as there are different interpretations. Research in a way that includes different kinds of autonomy, however the question is whether technology disable a person in terms of reflective decision-making or value-reasoned choice and action (Catena 2026)? That means that deciding whether someone is autonomous or not does not depend on the fact that he or she actually touched the button at the end of the pathway, but instead whether he or she was given access to all information, competencies and alternatives necessary for being able to act freely.

Each of these scenarios in the report claims AI will erode human agency, but the erosion is not due to AI itself, it is how we deploy it. On the contrary, it can also serve to broaden the autonomy of individuals by providing information, recognizing alternatives and assisting people in overcoming cognitive biases. The key is how you design AI systems to facilitate decision making — or even co-opt the decision-making process in secret ways, usurping judgment — especially for consequential decisions as this scenario poses threats to individual liberties, opportunities, health and wealth.

2. Arguments in Favor

2.1 Over-reliance and automation bias

AI may vitiate autonomy in part due to what is known as an automation bias — the inclination of human beings to prefer an automated output over their own judgment with independent decision-making perhaps detrimentally influenced. This is significant, because being truly independent means more than just disregarding a recommendation from someone else; it requires the willingness to evaluate why one person would recommend something and then reject that person or even others. A 2026 study in the Scientific Reports journal studied the bias towards trust in AI recommendations showing that success of decisions made with AI help, were based on conviction and reliance on AI technology and possibility of wrong and biased recommendations (Pearson et al.

Yet the evidence does not support unfaltering algorithmic obedience across contexts. Alon-Barkat and Busuioc have grown mixed: algorithmic advice did not show a systematic bias toward algorithms when compared with similar recommendations from humans. This means that the autonomy threat is contextual, as it depends on trust (or lack thereof), task complexity, level of user expertise and adequacy with regards to who actually has authority over decisions and actions following the recommendation (Alon-Barkat & Busuioc, 2023).

2.2 Recommendation systems can shape the choice environment

Final word autoregulation on all AI systems is out of the question; they may have far-reaching impacts through the options each person can choose from. This means that search engines, streaming platforms, social media and e-commerce sites can basically keep tailoring the environment a user occupies. Legally speaking, the person is freely chosen, but an algorithm has made a decision on the conditions of that choice. By filtering, personalising and shaping preferences recommender systems can mediate human activity — with all that implies for personal autonomy (del Valle & Lara, 2024).

Which is ethically salient in relation to the development of systems that are designed first and foremost with engagement, profit or predictability of behaviour maximisation at their core. Personalised nudges can be incredibly subtle that the users might not even say how did they know this choice was proffered. Catena (2026) analyzes this overview and presents some of the central topics in the autonomy debate as driven by whether deliberation and behaviour are influenced, manipulated or shaped through AI mediation. Therefore, the threat of artificial intelligence consists not so much in dictation as, rather, in altering the parameters that undertake decision making.

2.3 Deskilling and cognitive dependence

Continued reliance on AI may also hinder the ability to make independent decisions. If this offloading happens sufficiently often, the person will use the underlying skill less. This is referred to as cognitive offloading (or deskilling) over time. In the world of work, such competencies are valuable because expertise can be understood as the ability to see what is abnormal; to push back on common practice; and to respond when a system malfunctions. A related point is made in Catena (2026) review when he indicates that AI might alter the very grounds for autonomous choice through automation and highlights how literature increasingly sketches impairment of cogni tive capacities, dependency or modification of human traits.

2.4 High-stakes decisions and unequal power

The biggest autonomy issues are those in which AI chooses for individuals, and that they generally have no real control over them anyway. We may see one right now in the latest Dutch childcare benefits scandal. Increasingly, however, risk profiles developed by the same algorithmic techniques were deployed against citizens by governments such as the Dutch tax authorities who reportedly developed a system for detecting potentially fraudulently applications for childcare benefits. Some of the factors considered while assessing risk include nationality. As noted by Amnesty International (2021), this lead to ethnical profiling and discrimination.

This case is an example of when the presence of AI does much more than influence preferences. It can shape the selection and opportunity structure of citizens. But if a system can induce practical autonomy — as we have defined it — to the point that those affected do not reasonably understand or cannot effectively contest its decision, then the real if not formal human accountability of a system is undermined.

3. Counter-Arguments (Against the Topic)

3.1 AI can expand human capacity

The best ad-hoc argument against this is: the AI adds autonomy. Because humans have restrictions in terms of time, memory, attention and vertical expertise; AI helps them to analyze large amounts of data, compare various alternatives, summarize it all up together and find patterns that are difficult to detect without assistance. Thus, Catena claims that AI can reduce some restrictions of liberty, therefore the introduction of AI is not a necessarily malicious event (Catena, 2026).

As another example, an AI could assist a doctor figure out what possible diagnoses are for a patient, or a student may use an AI tool to structure relevant academic research in an order that makes sense, or a consumer might receive a custom pack of options as opposed to skimming through tens of thousands. So in each of these cases, the AI works to broaden the range of possibilities available to a user (or at least their practical accessibility), not narrow it; they are ultimately accepted or rejected by the human in the loop that decides which paths merit further exploration.

3.2 Assistance is different from replacement

AI recommendation should not automatically be treated as AI control. The distinction between decision support and decision replacement is crucial. The OECD's AI Principles state that trustworthy AI should respect human rights and democratic values, including individual autonomy, and should include human agency and oversight. They also emphasize transparency and the ability of affected people to challenge AI outputs (OECD, 2024).

UNESCO similarly places human rights, dignity, transparency, fairness, and human oversight at the center of its Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence (UNESCO, 2021). These principles recognize that people can use AI as a powerful aid without handing over responsibility for the final judgment.

3.3 Choice and control can preserve autonomy

Research also suggests that autonomy-supportive design can improve people's relationship with recommendation systems. Fink, Newman, and Haran found across three online experiments that users were more likely to accept algorithmic recommendations when they had greater choice or control, such as receiving multiple recommendations rather than one fixed suggestion (Fink et al., 2024). This is a useful insight: preserving autonomy does not necessarily mean reducing AI assistance. Instead, systems can be designed to give users meaningful options and control over how recommendations are presented.

4. Critical Discussion

It means the correct question is not to ask whether AI affects human decisions. Printed on letters and signs, in magazines, pamphlets all kinds of communication devices from the mass media to gossip about people to informal chats. The more relevant question is, does AI influence lead to reflective choice or bypass it. For example a calculator alters how people do arithmetic, and a navigation app alters how people choose routes, but these are tools that generally serve human ends. The ethics of AI become increasingly problematic when it becomes difficult for anyone to question the recommendation, when crucial alternatives are hidden from sight or in some cases when people no longer have the requisite knowledge and/or power necessary to disagree.

One helpful set of criteria is to think in terms of three conditions for autonomymeaningful exercise of autonomy, if you willunderstanding, competence, and voluntariness. AI might help organize information and demonstrate trade offs thereby increasing understanding. It could offer decision support; this may enhance performance. It can even promote voluntariness by helping people find options that they would have otherwise overlooked. But with every benefit, there must be a cost. But opaque systems can diminish understanding, excessive automation might undermine competence, and personalized manipulation might compromise voluntariness (Catena, 2026; del Valle & Lara, 2024).

You can see here that you need human oversight, but not just having some human in the process. This human needs right to actually challenge, override and interpret the system. A good example of this principle is the EU AI Act. Article 14 states that high-risk AI systems must have effective human oversight in place and draws attention to the fact that persons responsible for oversight need to have an understanding of system limitations as well as awareness of the possibility of automation bias (European Union, 2024).

I therefore think that a realistic approach combines AI support with transparency, user agency, contestability, and proportional human oversight. For Less Risky Uses, Simply Disclose and Control Higher-risk systems ought to have more robust monitoring, require that a trained human make decisions, be accompanied by records documenting how decisions are made and offer significant avenues for appeal. The OECD principles also emphasize that AI systems should be subject to the same principles of explainability and accountability as other forms of decision support, available for overriding when necessary (OECD, 2024).

5. Conclusion: My Justified Position

To me, while the autonomy of people in decision-making can be diminished by AI, it is not a necessary or inevitable process. The real danger is not AI help but moving the practical power of decision making away from people and passing it to opaque, unchallengeable or in a psychological sense unfightable systems. Automation bias, recommendation-driven choice environments, cognitive dependency and transparent high-stakes decision-making undermine real self-direction.

But AI could also enhance autonomy: when it increases access to information, lessens cognitive load, and prompts people toward alternatives. Hence, society ought to respond by not taking AI out of the decision-making. The alternative would rather be that AI is designed to assist human judgement. Users should be aware of when or how AI is involved, know about applicable limitations, receive material choices, and retain the choice to express objections or contest recommendations. Real human oversight, not symbolic must be performed on information in high-stakes situations. It is this balance that allows the efficiency of AI to be useful without impinging on the human freedom and responsibility that renders ethical choices meaningful.

6. References

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